

The Claremont City Council held a meeting on Wednesday, June 9, 2021, in the Council Chambers of City Hall.

The meeting was called to order by Mayor Lovett at 6:30 p.m.

Members of the Council present:

At-Large Councilor Dale Girard
At-Large Councilor Erica Sweetser
Assistant Mayor Allen Damren
Mayor Charlene Lovett
At-Large Councilor Debora Matteau
At-Large Councilor Nicholas Koloski
Ward II Councilor James Contois – home, alone (because of COVID-19 concerns, joined via Zoom)
Ward III Councilor Jonathan Stone

Absent:

Ward I Councilor Andrew O’Hearne

Also present:

Edward Morris, City Manager
Mary Walter, Finance Director

AGENDA CHANGES

None

REPORT OF THE SECRETARY

A motion was made by Councilor Matteau and seconded by Assistant Mayor Damren to accept the minutes of the May 26, 2021, City Council meeting, as amended.

Mayor Lovett said the meeting was called to order by her at 5:30 p.m. She said on page 14, during the water and sewer rates discussion, she wanted it to indicate that Councilors were interested in Options 1 (proposed rate structure) and 2 (freeze all rates Year 1), and had no interest in Options 3 (freeze sewer rates Year 1) or 4 (One Water Rate); and in order to move the discussion along, Councilor Matteau made a motion.

Roll call vote:

Girard - yes

Demars - yes

Damren - yes

Matteau - yes

Koloski - yes

Contois - yes

Stone - yes

Lovett - yes

Motion carried 8-0.

MAYOR'S NOTES

Mayor Lovett presented a Rural PRIDE 2021 proclamation to Matt Mooshian.

Matt Mooshian, Ward 2, introduced Stephanie, Executive Director, TLC Family Resource Center. He talked about the Pride Month Celebrations including a mix of in person and virtual events. Next Wednesday, 5:30 p.m., there will be a Pride flag raising in Broad Street Park and at the end of the week, there will be a picnic at the Visitors Center Green.

Mayor Lovett mentioned the Memorial Day events.

CITY MANAGER'S REPORT

- **Water Shutoff Update** –. The City's water shutoffs will start on June 8th for past due bills from 8/28/2020. The City started with 113 shutoffs, and of that number, 31 have paid their bill. Of the remaining 82 shutoffs, approximately 45 have contacted the Water Department or are tenants. The remainder will receive a door posted notice which will give another 15 days, per City Ordinance. As of the date of this report, the City is planning to shut off water service to 37 water users. This number changes daily, and I will update the City Council at the City Council meeting as to how many shutoffs have occurred.
- **DPW Updates** – I have a few updates I would like to bring to the City Council's attention. First, the City has installed three speed tables on Water Street. These speed tables will allow the City to maintain speed control along Water Street year-round. These tables will also remove the need for City staff to install and remove the speed bumps along Water Street. Second, The City has paved a base course of pavement on Franklin Street next to the Sullivan House project. We will not be paving the final course until after exterior construction is completed on the County project. We have coordinated this with the County and the paving company so there is no damage caused to the finished surface. Finally, Line Painting, including crosswalks and other street markings is slated to begin June 7th. The line painting will be done at night, starting at 9PM and continuing until morning. This painting should last throughout the week.

- Tour of Honor-** The Tour of Honor Ride to Remember is a season-long, self-directed ride to memorials and monuments around the continental U.S., Alaska and Hawaii. The event is put together to benefit different veterans' charities. The tour begins April 1 and ends on October 31 of each year. Registered riders can visit as many sites as they want, using any route they choose, and each rider is asked to take pictures as they visit the memorials, to be submitted back to the tour organizers. Trophies are awarded to the first three riders to visit all of the memorials in a state (or region). 2021 has an all-new set of memorial sites to visit, with new roads and new experiences for any avid motorcyclist, and I am happy to announce that the war memorials in Broad Street Park in Claremont have been added to this tour.
- Fire Engine Sale** – The City of Claremont has entered a sale agreement for Engine #1 with the Hatfield, WI, Volunteer Fire Department for the sum of \$145,000.00, less a 7% broker fee to Fire Tech in Randolph Vermont. Using a formula as a predictor of the value, the broker indicated a reasonable price would be \$137,000. We listed the engine in September of 2020 for \$170,000.00, hoping to get the best sale price possible. Over time, we slowly dropped the price until we got to \$152,500.00 and that is when Hatfield flew to Claremont to look at the truck. After some negotiation, we settled on a price of \$145,000. When the wire transfer is received, the truck will be shipped to WI via motor carrier at the buyer's expense.
- Donations** – The City has received \$14,809.98 in donations, in-kind gifts, as well as cash from 1/1/2021 through 6/01/2021. Many thanks to all who have donated to make the City a better place. These donations benefit our residents and our community and we are grateful for each gift.

Summary of Donations		Received 1/1/21 through 6/1/2021
Police - Safety Equip	\$	10,000.00
Kurt Beek Memorial Garden	\$	150.00
Parks Special Events - Movie Night/Lollipop Sponsorships/Chili Cookoff	\$	500.00
Vets Park General Field Renovations	\$	1,150.00
Fire - Forestry Equipment Donations	\$	-
Fire - Misc Donations - Carbon/Fire Alarm replacements	\$	1,000.00
CSB Community Center Donations	\$	545.00
Scholarship Funds / Rene Lacasse et.al	\$	1,464.98
Totals		\$ 14,809.98

- ATV Update** - I have talked with Steve Wilkie, Sullivan County ATV Club (SCATV), and he stated the ATV Club planned to open the trails on June 12th. The Club is having signs made for Veterans Park Road and Cat Hole Road. They plan on having 7 trail patrol

people on the trails, and volunteers at the Burger King parking lot to talk with every rider about respecting the neighbors along the trail and especially along Veterans Park Road and Cat Hole Road.

COVID-19 Update

- **COVID-19 Update** – At the time this report was written, active COVID-19 cases throughout the State of New Hampshire have continued to decline with a 40% decrease in active cases across the state from May 26, 2021 to June 1, 2021. The City of Claremont currently has 7 active cases, with the current Sullivan County infection rate at .59%.

Today there were 12 active cases; the infection rate is at .79%; and the vaccination rate is 50.7% fully and 59% with one dose.

Vaccinations are now available for anyone over the age of 12 in the State of New Hampshire (resident or non-resident). Drop-in vaccinations are also available. This means it is not required for people to make an appointment through the State. Citizens can go to Walmart or CVS Pharmacies to receive COVID-19 vaccinations. As of June 1, 2021 New Hampshire's vaccination rate is 48.5% fully vaccinated and 59% with 1 dose.

As we enter the summer season, the City is working with local organizations to plan and bring back many community events. We ask everyone to please be mindful and respectful of others by maintaining the proper social distancing and to wear masks when this is not possible.

Councilor Contois said there was still one speed bump on Water Street. Mr. Morris said it will be removed for winter.

Regarding the COVID-19 report, Councilor Contois wanted it known that there are 1,357 people who are dead in NH because of COVID-19.

Mayor Lovett brought up the hydrant flow testing to be done as reported in the Fire Department's Report and that the most recent data was collected in 1990. Mr. Morris said that a portion of the hydrants should be done annually to keep the data up to date. Council asked for report once it's done, and then a plan moving forward. Mr. Morris will work with the Fire Chief to get that information.

Mayor Lovett highlighted the Library's Summer Reader Program.

Mr. Morris said the City is moving forward with the July 4th Fireworks show in Monadnock Park.

Councilor Koloski thanked the Public Works Department for its report as there is more information in it than there has been.

Councilor Girard asked for an explanation of the Rectangular Rapidly Flashing Beacons (RRFBs) to be installed. Mr. Morris said they are the same as the ones by the CSB Community Center. A set will be placed by the Parking Garage and on North Street.

APPOINTMENT TO BOARDS AND COMMITTEES

Claremont Community Television, Inc. (CCTV) Board of Directors

A motion was made by Assistant Mayor Damren and seconded by Councilor Matteau to appoint Dana McGrath to seat 2 of the Claremont Community Television, Inc. (CCTV) Board of Directors.

There was a discussion because Dana McGrath had applied for three board seats (Claremont Community Television, Inc. (CCTV) Board of Directors, Parks and Recreation Commission, and Tax Increment Finance District Advisory Board – Downtown). Mr. Morris said the TIFD only meets once a year.

Ms. McGrath joined the meeting via Zoom. She said that she just moved to Claremont at the end of February and that she wanted to get involved in her new community. She feels able to commit the time needed for the three boards.

Councilor Koloski said that having a board applicant appear before the Council was good.

Roll call vote:

Girard - yes

Demars - yes

Damren - yes

Matteau - yes

Koloski - yes

Contois - yes

Stone - yes

Lovett - yes

Motion carried 8-0.

Parks and Recreation Commission

A motion was made by Councilor Matteau and seconded by Councilor Girard to appoint Dana McGrath to seat 3 – At-Large of the Parks and Recreation Commission.

Roll call vote:

Girard - yes

Demars - yes

Damren - yes

Matteau - yes
Koloski - yes
Contois - yes
Stone - yes
Lovett - yes
Motion carried 8-0.

Tax Increment Finance District Advisory Board - Downtown

A motion was made by Assistant Mayor Damren and seconded by Councilor Matteau to appoint Dana McGrath to seat 4 of the Tax Increment Finance District Advisory Board - Downtown.

Councilor Girard asked if this appointment can go through June 30, 2022. This is a one-year appointment and would expire June 30, 2021. Mr. Morris said that it can start July 1, 2021, and then it would expire June 30, 2022.

Roll call vote:
Girard - yes
Demars - yes
Damren - yes
Matteau - yes
Koloski - yes
Contois - yes
Stone - yes
Lovett - yes
Motion carried 8-0.

Parks and Recreation Commission (continued)

A motion was made by Assistant Mayor Damren and seconded by Councilor Matteau to re-appoint Robert Pickul to seat 5 – At-Large of the Parks and Recreation Commission.

Roll call vote:
Girard - yes
Demars - yes
Damren - yes
Matteau - yes
Koloski - yes
Contois - yes
Stone - yes
Lovett - yes
Motion carried 8-0.

Councilor Koloski said that someone had brought to his attention that the Board Vacancy list showed some boards as “Full Board” and they had assumed it meant all seats were vacant, when, in fact, they were all filled. He asked if different wording could be used to avoid confusion.

CITIZEN’S FORUM

Norm Blouin, Ward 3, was concerned that with level funding, and that Water and Sewer would not have the funds to be able to handle a catastrophe. Mr. Morris explained Water and Sewer would use the funds that are available until those run out and then use the reserves. Mr. Blouin talked about the Public Works Department using an arm mower which is a slow moving machine. He is not in favor of the City raising taxes, because the people who live here cannot afford it. The City has to figure out a way to be more realistic with the budget. He was not in favor of the proposed truck route which is going by the church and bank.

Chuck Allen, Ward 3 resident and member of the Arrowhead Recreation Club, gave an Arrowhead Update.

- Made up of 100% volunteers
- Arrowhead is owned by the City of Claremont
- Since 2000, added over \$500,000 in improvements, which has become City assets
- Capital improvements last spring and summer: 1960s vintage windows and doors replaced, new heating system for the main floor installed, air conditioning added to the main floor, and aging roof resingled
- This past season was a challenge because of COVID-19: implemented reservation system for tubing, and limited inside capacity
- Received large unexpected increase in insurance cost
- Operational days: average 37; last year 29; year before 36
- Customer visits: average 4,200; last year 3,400; year before 4,300
- Operational hours: average 2,500; last year 1,700; year before 2,300
- Nonoperational hours: average 2,000; last year 1,500; year before 1,900
- Total hours: average 4,500; last year 3,248; year before 4,270
- Always need new volunteers
- Looking to add people to the board
- Need to have 15 volunteers, but typically only have 4

OLD BUSINESS

Legislative Update

Mayor Lovett said June 3 the Senate passed their version of the budget for FY22 and 23, which included Meals & Rooms tax revenue (30% of revenue brought in to the municipalities), and restored State Aid Grant for wastewater projects. The next step is the Committee of Conference. She said people should contact their Representatives and/or Senator to make it known they want support for these revenues. This type of revenue is very important to municipalities.

Ordinance 586 Water Rates – First Reading

The purpose of this proposed change is to amend the City's water rates in order to establish new rate schedules for the next five (5) fiscal years from 2022 to 2026. The changes to these rates reflect the City's need to address estimated operating costs and existing debt obligations of the Claremont Water System. The increases to each rate schedule seek to implement an incremental change for each fiscal year in order to responsibly introduce such charges for the City's water users in a fashion that does not impose a drastic financial impact for any particular fiscal year covered by this amendment.

It is the hope of the City that the slight annual increase to these water rates, for each fiscal year under this amendment, will be a gradual and acceptable way to address the financial needs of the City's Water System during this timeframe, but avoids users experiencing an extreme increase of cost in any of the years under these new schedules. This change is requested by the City Manager.

Alex Gleeson, Public Works Director, gave a brief overview of the water and sewer rates and the City's proposed rate changes.

Mayor Lovett talked about the presentation that had been previously received from Public Works and that justification for the rate increases included operating costs, depreciation and debt obligations, however, depreciation was missing from the Explanation of Proposed Action and Section 3 Annual Review of the proposed ordinance.

There was a typo in the fee for the 1" Meter Size for FY2026; it was presented as \$56.75, but should have been \$51.75. Council agreed that was a substantial change and that this ordinance should go back to first reading.

Councilor Koloski asked about current water disconnections and previous years. Mr. Morris can get that information.

Ordinance 588 Sewer Rates – First Reading

The purpose of this proposed change is to amend the City's sewer rates in order to establish new rate schedules for the next five (5) fiscal years from 2022 to 2026. The changes to these rates reflect the City's need to address estimated operating costs and existing debt obligations of the Claremont Sewer System. In addition, the Ordinance seeks to amend the City's Code in order to reflect that these sewer rates will be charged, going forward, on a quarterly basis rather than the semiannual basis that currently exists within the Code. As with the City's water rates, the City is seeking to implement incremental changes to the sewer rates in order to avoid drastic increases, in any particular fiscal year, for users of the City's Sewer System.

It is the hope of the City that changing the sewer rates and by creating additional billing periods for each fiscal year, will provide for the financial needs of the Sewer System in a responsible and gradual fashion. This change is requested by the City Manager.

Mayor Lovett said there was an error in the Sewer Flat Rate for FY2026. It was listed as \$198.90, but should have been \$204.05.

She had the same concerns as she did for Ordinance 586 that this ordinance should reflect that the rate increase was due to operating costs, debt obligations and depreciation.

Council agreed to use Option 1 (City's proposed changes).

Budget

Mr. Morris listed some areas to take money from to put toward Paving:

- Encumber \$81,000 from last year to be used for union negotiations, so we could use the \$51,600 from compensation, negotiations for Paving
- Cut GASB = \$50,000
- Increase Motor Vehicle Revenue (lot of boat registrations have been received) = add \$30,000
- Add Sweetwater Hydro PILOT = \$4,000
- Total to move to Paving = \$135,600

Mr. Morris would not like to remove the money from the budget for the vacancies at this time, but instead review in January/February timeframe and move the money that had not been spent. If the positions are not filled, he expected to be able to move \$100,000 to Paving. Currently, there are two Police Officers that are deployed with the Military. If Meals & Rooms are approved by the State, there may be another \$100,000-\$150,000 that could be moved to Paving. All totaled, this could bring us close to the \$1 million for Paving that Councilor Demars had mentioned earlier.

Mr. Morris said with COVID reimbursements, the amount going into Fund Balance will be closer to \$900,000. Because of COVID shutdown, the Library has leftover money in its Part-Time budget and they will ask to encumber \$20,000 of that for carpet at the Library.

Councilor Koloski is not in favor of reducing the amount to be put in for GASB. He's not comfortable increasing revenues from Motor Vehicle Registrations. He would be in favor of not going after the vacant positions with the understanding that can be revisited. Ms. Walter said that she has reviewed the revenues from Motor Vehicle Registrations and she is comfortable with the \$30,000.

Assistant Mayor Damren agreed with Councilor Koloski about not deferring GASB. Regarding taking away vacant position salaries, it would be hard to get that back. He agreed with the \$51,600. He said we owe employees a discussion about the wage & salary survey. We need to be careful moving the salary money.

Councilor Matteau said at the Saturday session that there was a \$151,000 figure that could be encumbered from Highway to put toward Paving. Mr. Morris said that has already been put on a purchase order for Paving. He said Public Works will ask to encumber another \$65,000 for Paving, so that would bring the total to about \$865,000 for Paving for the current year.

Councilors asked clarifying questions and received answers.

Mr. Blouin asked a clarifying question and Mr. Morris answered.

Mayor Lovett asked that the above information, regarding possible Paving money be forwarded to the Council.

Task Force for City Historical Artifacts Discussion

Councilor Koloski submitted the following proposal.

Arts & Cultural Resources Preservation Committee

The Arts & Cultural Resources Preservation Committee would be a very valuable resource in our community that will assist the Claremont City Council in honoring the City's past as it looks towards the future. They would work cooperatively with existing boards and commissions to:

- Be advocates for existing cultural assets in the city.
- Identify preservation projects that are meaningful, broadly appealing, and help enhance the history and uniqueness of the City of Claremont.
- Assist the City Council with guidance on the inventory and preservation of city-owned historical artifacts and property.

Establishment and Purpose.

The purpose of the Arts & Cultural Resources Preservation Committee would be to assist the Claremont City Council in preserving the historical integrity of Claremont, New Hampshire by identifying City-owned historical assets and providing guidance on recording and preserving these assets.

Composition; appointment; qualifications.

The Arts & Cultural Resources Preservation Committee shall consist of seven (7) members, all of whom shall be residents of the City. There shall be one member who is a representative of the Claremont Historical Society, one member representing the Historic District Commission and, one member who is a representative of Claremont City Council, joined by 4 members at large.

Appointment to the Arts & Cultural Resources Preservation Committee shall be made by the City Council. It shall serve as an advisory body to the City Council.

All members of the Arts & Cultural Resources Preservation Committee shall be selected upon the basis of their interest in art, historic preservation, and overall familiarity with the City of Claremont. Individuals with professional experience in historic preservation, art, architecture, or construction are strongly encouraged to apply. The City Council should strive to include members representative of a diverse community.

Terms of office.

The terms of office of the members of the Arts & Cultural Resources Preservation Committee shall be two (2) years.

Duties generally.

Duties of the Arts & Cultural Resources Preservation Committee include the following:

- a. Preparing and maintaining an inventory of historic, cultural and architectural areas, sites, structures and objects in Claremont, New Hampshire;
- b. Developing proposed priorities, and plans for promoting and advancing historic preservation of City-owned Historical assets in Claremont, NH.
- c. Making recommendations to the Claremont City Council that assure that City projects and City-funded activities enhance the historic qualities of identified historic properties when this is feasible and appropriate;
- d. Making recommendations to the Claremont City Council that assure that City construction projects consider the quality of architecture when this is feasible and appropriate;
- e. Working collaboratively with the Claremont Historical Society, Claremont Historic District Commission and others to identify and preserve the City's historic, cultural and architectural areas, sites, structures and objects;
- f. Assisting City staff with seeking grants, donations of funds and/or works of art for purposes of promoting and advancing historic preservation in Claremont, New Hampshire.
- g. Making recommendations to the Claremont City Council regarding allocation and budgeting of funds for historic preservation projects, the acquisition or commissioning of Public Art and/or for the maintenance of Public Art;
- h. Developing proposed policies, priorities, and plans for promoting, advancing, and maintaining Public Art.
- i. Encouraging the promotion of New Hampshire artists in City art projects;
- j. Encouraging citizen input and involvement in the City's design and selection of Public Art;
- k. Coordinating with the private sector and other governmental agencies in promoting arts and cultural excellence as a tool for the encouragement of economic development, business relocation and tourism;
- l. Assisting City staff with seeking grants, donations of funds and/or works of art for purposes of expanding the Public Art collection or the maintenance of the collection including landscaping and hardscaping of public art;

- m. Organizing and promoting Public Art that celebrates the City of Claremont and its unique cultural heritage;
- n. Carrying out such other duties as may be required or established by the City Council;
- o. Development of a proposed set of incentives in support of the above.

Councilor Koloski gave some background for his proposal. He said he would like this to be similar to neighboring communities.

Councilors discussed this. Some were concerned about the City having a hard time filling current board seats.

Mr. Morris said he talked to Planning and Development Director Nancy Merrill and Resource Coordinator deForest Bearse and they were concerned about having enough staff time to manage more boards. He would like to have a committee to put this together. The Historic District Commission has been talking about how to transition to a Heritage Commission. A Heritage Commission would do a lot of things that are on this list, so it would be a duplication of efforts. He talked about keeping the quasi-judicial portion of the Historic District Commission only to the Historic District, and add the cultural and artistic portions of this to that same committee and have one committee that is registered with the state as a Heritage Commission. He said that Ms. Merrill and Ms. Bearse were in support of the idea. He said that David Messier, Historic District Commission Chair, was also in support. Mr. Morris would like to meet with a Councilor, or two, and staff, himself and someone from the Historic District Commission to look through this to see how it could work and then to come back to the Council in a month or two with a proposal.

Mr. Morris said that membership could go up to 7, with 5 alternate members, if it is a state registered Heritage Commission.

Councilor Contois suggested more weight should be added to the Claremont Historical Society.

Mayor Lovett would like to make sure that Claremont's military artifacts and military history are also included.

When asked, Councilor Koloski said he would work with Mr. Morris on this. Council concurred. Mr. Morris will come back to the Council with an update. Mayor Lovett said to bring it to the first meeting in July.

NEW BUSINESS

Resolution 2021-32 Fire Truck Sale Proceeds to Capital Reserve – Public Hearing

WHEREAS the City Council in 1998 adopted a fire apparatus replacement plan and established a Capital Reserve Fund to effectuate this plan; and

WHEREAS implementation of this plan results from time to time in the sale of excess fire equipment, vehicles or apparatus that is no longer useful, appropriate or necessary to be retained by the City; and

WHEREAS upon disposal of such excess fire equipment, vehicles or apparatus in accordance with the Claremont City Code, the City Council by Resolution 2006-8 authorized the *net* proceeds of any such sale to be deposited into said Capital Reserve Fund each year in an amount not to exceed \$25,000; and

WHEREAS the sale of the City's 2006 E-One Pumper Truck has resulted in the net proceeds of \$134,850.00, deposit of the entire net proceeds being determined as the most fiscally prudent manner for reserving funds for acquisition of future replacement of the City's fire apparatus, vehicles or equipment;

NOW THEREFORE BE IT RESOLVED that the City Manager or his designees are hereby authorized to deposit the entire net proceeds of \$134,850.00 from the sale of the 2006 E-One Pumper Truck into the Capital Reserve Fund for the purpose of reserving funds for future acquisition of fire apparatus, vehicles or equipment for the Claremont Fire Department; and

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED that the Council hereby authorizes the City Manager or his designees to undertake all actions and execute all documents as may be required to implement this resolution. (*Majority vote required*)

Fire Chief Bryan Burr gave an overview of this request.

There was a discussion about the cap of \$25,000 that was established with Resolution 2006-8 and how to remove that cap.

Council agreed there should be an agenda item, "Rescind Resolution 2006-8 and to Replace it With Resolution ____." Councilor Koloski would like to see that done for every department, so that whenever equipment is sold, the proceeds from the sale be left in that department's capital reserve.

Mayor Lovett said in the first Whereas, to add ", titled Fire Apparatus Equipment Reserve," after Capital Reserve Fund as that is the way it is listed in the Finance Report.

A motion was made by Councilor Girard and seconded by Councilor Koloski to adopt Resolution 2021-32 Fire Truck Sale Proceeds to Capital Reserve.

Councilor Girard read the resolution into the record.

Mayor Lovett opened the public hearing.

Norm Blouin asked clarifying questions and Chief Burr responded to those questions.

Roll call vote:

Girard - yes

Demars - yes

Damren - yes

Matteau - yes

Koloski - yes

Contois - yes

Stone - yes

Lovett - yes

Motion carried 8-0.

Resolution 2021-31 Overspend Welfare Budget – Public Hearing

BE IT RESOLVED by the Claremont City Council, after a public hearing duly noticed, that it hereby grants permission to overspend the Welfare Department 2021 Budget, as approved, by up to \$25,000.00 to cover client costs, as required by New Hampshire RSA 165:1 et seq.

Such department over-expenditures shall not exceed the total bottom line appropriated for 2021.
(2/3 Vote Required)

Suzanne Carr, Welfare Director, talked about housing costs and the pandemic causing a “perfect storm.” There is limited shelter space. The eviction moratorium means there has not been a lot of movement in housing. They normally budget for 4 or 5 burials and they have had 7 so far. The request is to overspend the budget by up to \$25,000.

A motion was made by Assistant Mayor Damren and seconded by Councilor Matteau to adopt Resolution 2021-31 Overspend Welfare Budget.

Assistant Mayor Damren read the resolution into the record.

Mayor Lovett opened the public hearing. No one spoke. She closed it.

Roll call vote:

Girard - yes

Demars - yes

Damren - yes

Matteau - yes

Koloski - yes

Contois - yes

Stone - yes

Lovett - yes

Motion carried 8-0.

Resolution 2021-33 Apply, Accept and Expend SRF Loan for Electrical Upgrades at Wastewater Treatment Plant – Public Hearing

WHEREAS, the City operates the Wastewater Treatment Plant at 338 Plains Road and wishes to replace aging and unsafe electrical equipment; and

WHEREAS, the City wishes to improve operating conditions of the facility during periods of power outage by increasing its standby generator capacity; and

NOW, THEREFORE, BE IT RESOLVED by the City Council to authorize the city manager, or his designees, to take such actions as may be necessary to file an application on behalf of the City for a loan from the State Revolving Fund (SRF) in the amount of \$3,469,000 in accordance with New Hampshire RSA 486:14 and Code of Administrative Rules Chapter Env Wq 500; and

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED that the City Treasurer, with the approval of the City Manager, is authorized to borrow up to \$3,469,000 from the State Revolving Fund (SRF) and to undertake all actions as may be required to accept and expend the funds to replace the electrical equipment at the Wastewater Treatment Plant; and

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED to raise and appropriate the amount of \$3,469,000 to design and construct the Project, with up to \$3,469,000 to come from the proceeds of said SRF loan (to have no impact on the tax rate); and

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED that the city manager, or his designees, are hereby authorized to undertake all actions and execute all documents, including the loan agreement, related to this resolution, and the city treasurer is hereby authorized to act on behalf of the Sewer Enterprise Fund by signing monetary disbursements. *(2/3 Vote Required)*

Mr. Gleeson gave a brief history. The Wastewater Treatment Plant was built in 1984. In 2018, Wright-Pierce Engineering completed a nitrogen and phosphorous evaluation and at that time, they evaluated the electrical equipment for code compliance.

Kristen Lemasney, Wright-Pierce Engineering, said the highest priority is to correct unsafe working conditions. Spare parts are now becoming obsolete. Regarding forgiveness, she said the state is committed to 10% forgiveness. This money has already been appropriated. This needs to be authorized before the end of the month. The generator is sized to accommodate future equipment and has a life expectancy of 20-30 years.

Regarding the loan, Mr. Gleeson said that financing the complete amount without the forgiveness will be around \$17,206 a month. Ms. Walter said the first payment will be due about one year after completion of the project.

A motion was made by Assistant Mayor Damren and seconded by Councilor Koloski to adopt Resolution 2021-33 Apply, Accept and Expend SRF Loan for Electrical Upgrades at Wastewater Treatment Plant.

Assistant Mayor Damren read the resolution into the record.

Councilors requested that the words “up to” be added in two places, before the dollar amount of \$3,469,000. Assistant Mayor Damren and Councilor Koloski agreed to those changes.

Mayor Lovett opened the public hearing. No one spoke. She closed it.

Roll call vote:

Girard - yes

Demars - yes

Damren - yes

Matteau - yes

Koloski - yes

Contois - yes

Stone - yes

Lovett - yes

Motion carried 8-0.

Private Lead Water Line Replacement Discussion

Mayor Lovett said that Claremont has a Lead Action Team and at its last meeting, they talked about the new copper and lead rule and that Claremont will have to revise some of its procedures regarding lead line replacement.

Mr. Gleeson showed a PowerPoint presentation starting with Operation Get the Lead Out. In September 2016, notices went to residents whose service lines possibly had lead in them. There are 48 remaining known lines within the City. Per ordinance, the City is responsible for the water line and the curb stop. The service line from the curb stop to the house is the responsibility of the property owner. Anticipated water line construction for August: Skinner Street, Pawtucket Avenue, Neilson Street, and Jackson Street. If the service line contains lead, it needs to be replaced. The City was awarded a \$500,000 Trust Fund Grant that could be used to pay for all or a portion of the private water line cost.

Mr. Morris said if a property owner refuses to replace the line, the City would have to get legal involved and the City would not hook onto the lead line until the line was replaced. The goal is to have all the lead out of the system within 3 years.

Mr. Gleeson said the average cost to property owners has been \$2,000 to \$12,000. Some can go much higher depending upon what was built on top of the line.

Councilor Koloski would like to see something come back to Council where the homeowner pays 25% and the City pays 75% using the grant. If the homeowner can't afford the 25%, then it goes onto the water bill.

Mayor Lovett said when that comes back to the Council, the City also needs to bring back the ordinance that says that service lines are the responsibility of the property owner from the curb stop to the home. She said we need to have in the ordinance that currently exists an exception when it identifies lead in the service lines. Mr. Morris said he can talk to legal; it is still the homeowner's responsibility. The City is not allowed to reconnect them to the system with the lead service line.

Arrowhead Alcohol Discussion

Councilor Stone, Policy Committee Chair, said Arrowhead Recreation Club had requested to increase the area where alcohol service and consumption would be allowed at Arrowhead. The Policy Committee recommended that it be allowed within a 200-foot radius of the lodge building. Councilor Koloski asked to confirm that the request did not include changing from beer and wine, only, to include hard liquor. Councilor Stone said that was correct.

Chuck Allen, Ward 3 resident and Arrowhead Recreation Area Club, said the major point was to allow the outside service within the secure area. He was satisfied with the 200-foot radius. Regarding allowing a full bar, he would be willing to discuss that, but the most important thing was to get approval for the outside service/consumption.

Mayor Lovett said the Licensing Board minutes noted that the Policy Committee recommended a 250-foot circumference around the lodge. Mr. Morris said he may have misspoken at the Licensing Board meeting. Mr. Allen was satisfied with 200-foot radius.

Regarding liability, Mr. Allen said that the caterers supply the City with liability insurance. Ms. Walter said the City would be notified if that insurance were to be cancelled.

Council agreed to have an amendment to the ordinance drafted.

Ordinance 587 Non-Union Employee Pay Schedule – First Reading

The purpose of this proposed change is to increase the maximum amount of rate of pay for non-union employees who are classified within Grade 1 of the City's Merit System and as shown on Attachment C of the 2021 Non-Union Employee Pay Schedule. The current maximum rate for a Grade 1 employee is \$12.20 per hour. The proposed modification seeks to increase that sum to \$15.30 per hour. It also establishes a dollar figure for the minimum rate of pay for Grade 4a (\$7.43/hr.) as well as makes increases to Grades 4b and 4c. The minimum rate of pay for Grade 4b is increased by 3% from Grade 4a making it \$7.65/hr. and Grade 4c is raised by 6% from Grade 4a which results in \$7.88/hr. No other grades or salary ranges will be impacted by this amendment.

Enactment of this Ordinance will repeal and readopt Attachment C of the 2109 Non-Union Employee Pay Schedule. This change is requested by the City Manager.

Councilor Koloski recused himself and left the Council table.

Mr. Morris said this proposal was to remove the words “Minimum Wage” and replace them with actual dollar amounts, which would include the 2.5% raise Council had approved. Changing to dollar amounts would allow those positions to be able to receive future approved pay raises. The other change was to move the maximum pay for grade 1 (Seasonal Employees) to the same amount as grade 2 (Part-time Employees).

The majority of the Councilors asked to include pay ranges for grades 4a, 4b, and 4c.

Councilor Contois said he wanted to go on the record that he believes in the \$15 minimum wage. Also, this keeps skirting the Paypoint HR wage survey. He thinks we need to establish a \$15 minimum wage, have a mid-point and a maximum.

There was a discussion about the pay for Call Firefighters. Councilors wanted to know what the requirements are for Call Firefighters. They get a stipend in addition to the hourly wage. Ms. Walter said the average Call Firefighter makes about \$2,200 a year. Nick Koloski, Call Firefighter, said that he has a good attendance record and he brings in about \$1,200 a year, including the stipend.

Councilor Matteau would like to know what other communities are paying and what the commitment is.

Council agreed this was not ready for first reading and that it needs to come back.

At 9:57 p.m. Councilor Koloski returned to the Council table.

COMMITTEE REPORTS

None

FUTURE AGENDA ITEMS AND DIRECTIVES

Assistant Mayor Damren said Council needs to determine when the wage survey comes back to the Council to determine what, if anything, is going to be done with it.

Councilor Matteau asked if the Rail Trail issue would be back on the agenda soon. Mr. Morris said he hope to get it back on in July.

Mr. Morris read off the action items.

- Tax Increment Finance terms
- Revise the board vacancy sheet to make it more clear
- Remove Arrowhead Update from the next agenda
- Water Shutoff comparison (this year and last year)
- Actuals of paving for budget this year
 - Right now, the system is showing \$805,496.37
- Send recommendations for Paving for 2022
- Work on Heritage Commission
- Resolution to rescind cap for fire trucks
- New resolution to lift the cap in all the departments
- Review water line ordinance
- Draft alcohol ordinance
- Call Firefighter pay and Merit Pay ordinance
- Future agenda:
 - Wage survey
 - Rail Trail

CONSULTATION WITH LEGAL COUNSEL

None

ADJOURNMENT

At 10:02p.m., a motion was made by Councilor Matteau and seconded by Assistant Mayor Damren to adjourn.

Roll call vote:

Girard - yes

Demars - yes

Damren - yes

Matteau - yes

Koloski - yes

Contois - yes

Stone - yes

Lovett - yes

Motion carried 8-0.

Respectfully Submitted,

Dorée M. Russell
Clerk to the Council